



MUSKETS (1650–1769)

Throughout the 17th century, European armies purchased muskets mostly as complete weapons, rather than in parts from various companies that were then assembled by craftsmen. These muskets were made by commercial gunmakers working under contract to government authorities. There was little control over size, shape, and quality, which made maintaining large numbers of firearms a major logistical problem. Ammunition supply for firearms was particularly difficult if their barrels did not have bores of a regulated size. In the early 18th century, many European countries sought to overcome this problem by introducing officially approved standard muskets, manufactured to specifications that were much more strictly controlled, so that all weapons of that type, or “pattern,” would be identical.

